NEW COVID VARIANT: SHOULD WE WORRY?

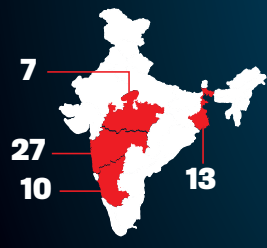
By SONALI ACHARJEE

WHAT IS IT?

- BA.2.75 is a branch of the BA.2 sub-variant of Omicron. BA.2 had caused the third wave in India earlier this year. BA.2.75 was first reported from samples in India on June 30 and has since spread to 10 other nations, including Japan, Australia, New Zealand, the UK, Germany and the US



- In India it has been found in 18% or around 80 recent samples. A total of 10 states have the variant, with the most cases found in Maharashtra (27), West Bengal (13), Karnataka (10), Madhya Pradesh (7)

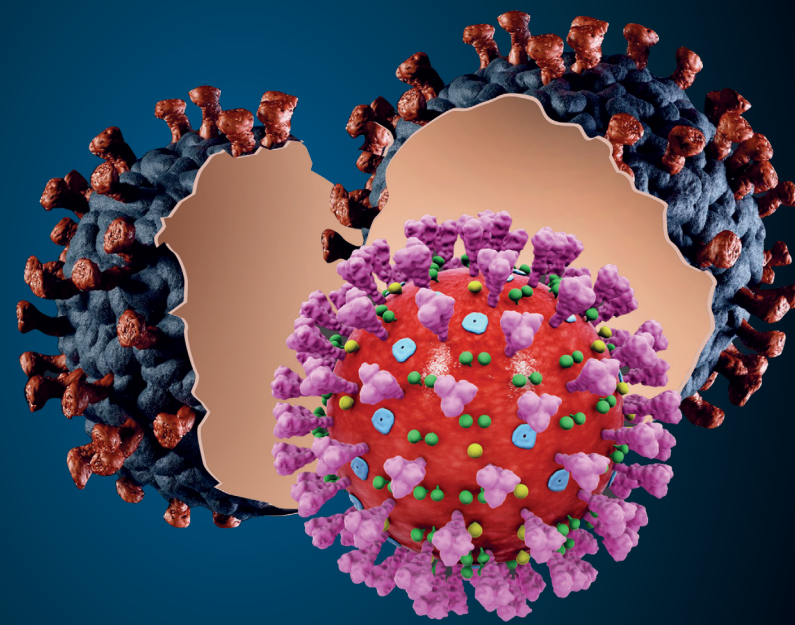


IS IT MORE DANGEROUS?

So far, clinical symptoms of the new variant remain the same as Omicron: fever, fatigue, upper respiratory infection, body ache being the most common. The disease itself is predicted to be no more severe than that caused by BA.2 as per current understanding

WHY ARE EXPERTS CONCERNED?

- India has the highest number of active cases: 130,713 as on July 12. It has been recording daily new cases in the range of 15,000 to 18,000 in the last week, an uptick from the 2,000-3,000 new cases per day a month ago.
- BA.2.75 has caught the attention of the central government, WHO and CDC because of 16 new mutations, including signature mutations on its spike–K147E, W152R, G446S and R493Q. The G446S, in particular, is worrisome as it can cause both immune escape and higher infectivity. This implies that this variant has significant potential for reinfections
- The new variant is being monitored and if it does cause more severe disease, or is shown to have a unique new mutation, then it could be classified as an entirely new variant and given its own Greek letter by the WHO



WHAT CAN WE DO?

- The protein subunit vaccine Covovax has been tested against Omicron variants and found to have a better degree of protection against it. Experts say this is best as the booster shot
- Masks, booster shots, social distancing and early diagnosis continue to be key

WILL OUR CURRENT VACCINES HELP?

- Studies are showing the current generation of vaccines to have lower efficacy against Omicron and its lineages. Experts say as the virus evolves, vaccine protection against infection will wane. It will, however, still help against severe disease and death
- In a recent study published in the *New England Journal of Medicine* by a team of Israeli researchers, the neutralising antibodies produced by vaccines developed for the ancestral 2020 Covid variant was lower by a factor of 6.4 against BA.1, by a factor of 7 against BA.2, and by a factor of 21 against BA.4 and BA.5

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY